

- RAG Learning

2.12 Comparative — Electoral and Party Systems

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 2 (Government and Politics of the USA and Comparative Politics)

Both countries elect their main legislative chamber by **single-member plurality**, and both have two dominant parties. That shared starting point makes the differences unusually instructive: where outcomes diverge despite identical rules, something other than the electoral system must be doing the work.

1. Side by side

	UK	USA
Main legislative system	First Past the Post	Single-member plurality
Head of government	Not separately elected	Separately (indirectly) elected via the Electoral College
Candidate selection	Local party members, under national rules and approved lists	Primaries — registered voters choose
Election timing	PM's discretion (since the 2022 FTPA repeal)	Constitutionally fixed calendar
Sub-national systems	AMS (Scotland; Wales until 2026), closed-list PR	Plurality almost throughout

	(Wales from 2026), STV (Northern Ireland)	
Campaign finance	Statutory spending limits; no paid TV political advertising	Effectively unlimited independent expenditure post- <i>Citizens United</i>
Campaign length	Weeks	Over a year, including the invisible primary
Party discipline	Strong — whipped voting	Formal sanctions weak (no control of nomination), but party cohesion now high — party-unity scores around 90 per cent since the 2000s because of ideological sorting. Cross-party voting is far less common than before the 1990s
Third parties	Win Westminster seats where support is concentrated (Lib Dems, SNP, Reform UK, Greens)	Effectively none in Congress
Referendums	Used for major constitutional questions	None nationally; extensive use at state level

2. Structural analysis

Why both have two-party systems

Duverger's law. Single-member plurality districts mean only the largest party in each district wins anything, so support spread evenly across the country wins nothing. Voters, donors and ambitious candidates all converge on the two viable parties. The USA reinforces this with the winner-take-all Electoral College — Ross Perot won ~19 per cent of the popular vote in 1992 and **zero** electoral votes.

Exam Tip: The fact that **the same rule produces the same outcome in two very different political cultures** is powerful evidence for the structural approach over the cultural one. And where the UK uses proportional systems — Scotland, Wales, Northern Ireland — genuinely multi-party systems emerge from the same electorate. Institutions, not national character, are doing the work.

But why does the UK sustain third parties and the USA not?

Because the structural explanation is incomplete without **geography**. FPTP rewards *concentrated* support: the SNP converted ~1.5 million votes into 56 seats in 2015 while UKIP's 3.9 million produced one. UK nationalist parties have territorially concentrated bases; US third-party support is dispersed nationally. The 2024 election made the point again: the Lib Dems won 72 seats on 12.2 per cent (concentrated), while Reform UK won 5 seats on 14.3 per cent (dispersed). This is the standard objection to a purely structural account.

3. Rational analysis — the discipline gap

This is the most examinable difference, and it has a precise institutional explanation.

Resource a politician needs	UK: who controls it	USA: who controls it
Nomination	The party (local members under national rules; approved lists; deselection possible)	Primary voters — the party cannot deselect
Campaign funding	Largely the party, within statutory limits	The candidate, from donors, PACs and Super PACs
Promotion	The party leadership, via the whips	Seniority and committee assignment, with leadership influence but no ministerial prize

The prediction follows directly: discipline should be strong where the party controls these resources and weak where it does not — which is what is observed in the *formal* levers. US party cohesion is nonetheless now high, but because of ideological sorting and fear of primary challenges rather than leadership sanctions. Discipline is not a cultural disposition but an outcome of who controls what a politician needs.

Fusion adds a further layer. In the UK a government falls if it loses Commons confidence, so a major rebellion is a constitutional act with potentially terminal consequences. In the USA the executive's survival is entirely independent of congressional votes, so dissent is nearly costless.

4. Cultural analysis

- **American individualism** — suspicion of centralised authority supports legislators building personal followings and being rewarded for independence. It also explains why primaries were adopted in the Progressive era specifically to weaken party machines.
- **British collective party tradition** — parties developed around organised collective interests (Labour founded by the unions in 1900), and voters choose a programme rather than an individual. Voting has historically been more strongly class-structured.
- **No US socialist party** — often attributed to the strength of the American dream of individual advancement and to ethnic and racial divisions fragmenting working-class organisation, though the structural barrier of plurality elections explains much of it too.

5. Campaign finance — the sharpest contrast

UK	USA
Statutory limits on national and constituency spending	<i>Buckley v Valeo</i> (1976): spending limits restrict protected speech
Restricted campaign period	<i>Citizens United</i> (2010): unlimited independent expenditure; Super PACs
Paid political advertising on TV prohibited	TV advertising is the dominant campaign medium

Problem: concentrated donor influence over *parties*

Problem: sheer volume and opacity of outside money ("dark money")

Exam Tip: The crucial structural point: the USA's problem is **constitutionally foreclosed from reform**. Because the Court treats spending restrictions as speech restrictions, meaningful change requires an amendment or the Court reversing itself. The UK regulates campaign spending by ordinary statute whenever it chooses. Same problem, entirely different remedial capacity.

6. Polarisation

Both have experienced dealignment, media fragmentation and insurgent challenges. But polarisation is **more pronounced in the USA**, for institutional reasons:

- **Ideological sorting** since the 1960s eliminated the cross-party overlap that made coalitions routine.
- **Safe districts** mean the primary is the only real contest, so legislators fear challenges from their own flank and compromise becomes dangerous.
- **Separation of powers** translates polarisation directly into gridlock, since the filibuster requires bipartisan majorities that no longer exist.
- **Deregulated partisan media**, with no UK equivalent given broadcasting impartiality rules.

UK polarisation over Brexit was real but **cut across parties rather than aligning with them**, which produced internal party crises rather than inter-party deadlock.

7. Similarities

- Both use single-member plurality for the main chamber and both are two-party dominant.
- Both main parties in each country are **broad coalitions** rather than narrow ideological groupings.
- Both have experienced **partisan dealignment** and weakening class-based voting.

- Both have opened **leadership selection** to wider participation, with similar consequences — leaders chosen by committed members or primary voters who may not command broader support.
- Both face concerns about money in politics, differing in form rather than in kind.

8. Are the systems converging?

Converging trends: dealignment, rising polarisation, insurgent challenges to established parties, personalised leadership-focused campaigns.

Diverging institutions: selection method (primaries vs party control), discipline, campaign finance regulation, third-party viability, and the use of referendums. *The trends converge while the institutions do not* — which is a good summary line for a conclusion.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Duverger's law	Single-member plurality elections tend to produce two-party systems
Primary	Election in which registered voters select a party's candidate (USA only)
Party discipline	The extent to which legislators vote with their party
Dealignment	Weakening of habitual class-based or partisan voting loyalties
Ideological sorting	Conservatives consolidating in one party, liberals in the other
Super PAC	Committee spending unlimited sums independently of campaigns
Safe seat / safe district	A constituency where the result is effectively predetermined
Spoiler effect	A third-party candidate splitting the vote and changing the winner

Essential examples

- **UKIP 2015** (3.9m votes, 1 seat) vs **SNP 2015** (1.5m votes, 56 seats) — concentration beats volume under plurality rules.
- **2024** — Lib Dems 72 seats on 12.2% (concentrated) vs Reform UK 5 seats on 14.3% (dispersed); Labour 411 seats on 33.7%; the SNP fell to 9 seats.
- **Ross Perot 1992** — 19 per cent of the vote, zero electoral votes.
- **Trump 2016** — primaries allowing an outsider to capture a party; impossible under UK selection rules.
- **Citizens United (2010)** vs **UK statutory spending limits** — the same problem, different remedial capacity.
- **Scotland (and Wales until 2026) under AMS** — the same electorate producing multi-party outcomes under different rules.
- **Corbyn 2015 / Truss 2022** — member-led selection producing leaders the parliamentary party opposed; the UK's nearest analogue to the primary problem.